

Cat Insurance Worth It — Action Checklist

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CALCULATE YOUR NUMBERS

- ☐ **Lifespan Estimate:** Use 15 years as your baseline for a healthy indoor cat to calculate lifetime premium costs, because using the wrong timeframe skews your entire financial projection and leads to bad decisions.
- ☐ **Premium Total:** Multiply your monthly premium by 12 and then by your cat's estimated remaining years to get the true total cost, because a \$25/month premium becomes \$5,000 or more over 15 years.
- ☐ **Vet Cost Research:** Gather average vet costs including routine visits (\$150-300), emergencies (\$1,500-\$8,000), and chronic conditions (\$300-600/month) to estimate what you might actually spend, because the math only works if you know both numbers.
- ☐ **Break-Even Point:** Compare your total lifetime premium cost against your estimated total vet costs to see if insurance will likely pay for itself, because insurance only makes financial sense when covered expenses exceed premium payments.

FACTOR HIDDEN COSTS

- ☐ **Lifetime Premiums:** Add up what you would pay in premiums over your cat's entire lifetime including projected rate increases, because most owners only calculate the monthly payment and are shocked by the real total cost over 15 years.
- ☐ **Rate History:** Ask providers for their historical rate increase patterns before signing up, because premiums often jump 15-25% when cats turn 8 years old and this dramatically affects your total cost calculation.
- ☐ **Self-Insurance Option:** Consider putting your monthly premium amount into a dedicated high-yield savings account instead, because a young healthy indoor cat will likely generate over \$10,400 over 15 years at 4% APY to cover emergencies.
- ☐ **Breed Health Costs:** Factor in whether your cat's breed predisposes them to hereditary conditions, because breeds like Persians, Maine Coons, and Siamese face significantly higher lifetime vet costs that may make insurance worthwhile.

CHOOSE A PROVIDER

- ☐ **Breed Exclusions:** Get the complete breed-specific exclusion list in writing before purchasing any policy, because paying premiums for a breed-prone condition that is excluded means you get no coverage when you need it most.
 - ☐ **Coverage Caps:** Verify the annual maximum payout limit on any policy you consider, because a \$20,000 cap sounds generous until your cat needs \$25,000 in treatment and you face a \$5,000 gap.
 - ☐ **Pre-Existing Clause:** Read the pre-existing condition definition carefully in any policy, because most providers permanently exclude conditions your cat had before coverage began and some have 12-18 month look-back periods.
 - ☐ **Complaint Data:** Look up your provider's complaint index and claim denial rate through your state's insurance department database, because a 3% denial rate versus a 1% rate at a competitor matters when your claim matters most.
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